Africa but who tragically passed away in a car accident. Francois was two years older than me and yet, when I was first chosen to play in the school cricket 1st XI, he always found time to encourage me. Such acts of kindness seem insignificant but they could not have been more important to a 15-year-old amongst older boys.

I remember one occasion when the whole team went to lunch at the Swart home before we played in a schools semifinal at the Technikon ground and his mother cooked for us. All these years later, I am still in contact with Tannie Sally, and she often sends me a text message when I am lucky enough to score runs.

It was people such as Francois Geldenhuys, also two years ahead of me at school and a fine cricketer who backed me when I was most in need. 'French', as we called him, was captain of the Northern Transvaal team at the Coca-Cola High Schools cricket week in 2000, and when our coach planned to put me at seven in the batting order, it was French who spoke up and insisted I be given the chance to open the innings.

Fortunately, I was able to take the opportunity; I scored a century that week, and went on to be included in the South African Colts team and then the South African schools team a year later, and so on. Would I have made that kind of progress if French had said nothing and I had been left to languish down the order? Nobody knows.

What is known is that there are thousands of exceptionally talented young sportsmen and -women all around the world who never realise their full potential simply because they get lost in the system, simply because they never have the chance to show what they can do at the crucial time. It is a simple fact that I got my chance because, at the crucial time for me, French Geldenhuys spoke up and insisted I open the innings.

And, in a school that offered much more than competitive sports teams, it was about people such as Gunther Bender, from Secunda, who was my roommate in the boarding house and who used to study the Bible